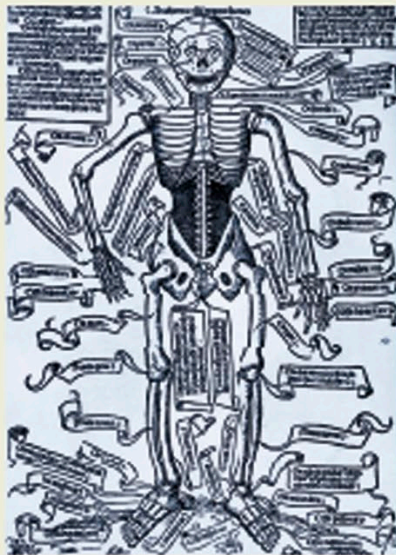


Anatomy

The practice of human dissection—cutting open bodies for examination—dates from around 300 BCE. This was when Ancient Greek physicians began to gain a true understanding of how the human body works. The study of anatomy declined after the collapse of the Roman Empire in the 5th century. It was not until the 15th century that there was renewed interest, leading to the influential work of Flemish-born anatomist Andreas Vesalius in mapping the human body.



First anatomical prints

The invention of printing allowed wider distribution of anatomical images, such as this 1493 woodcut of a skeleton by French physician Richard Helain. It has inaccuracies, such as an over-large pelvis, and too many teeth.



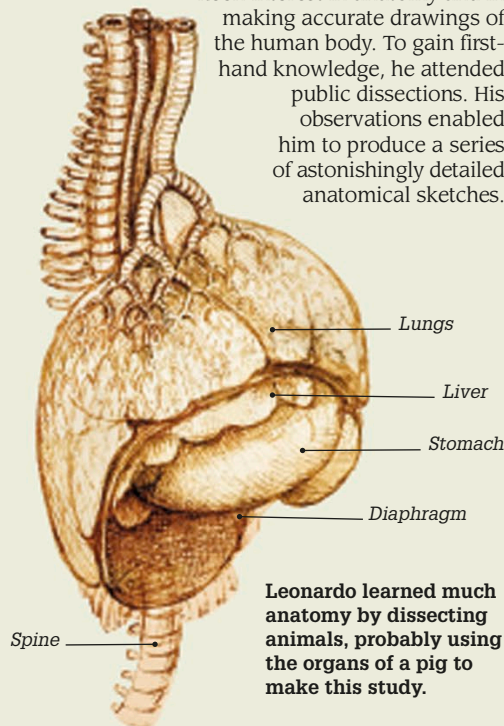
This woodcut is from Brunschwig's *Book of Surgery*, showing his collection of surgical tools, which included scissors, forceps, and saws.

Tools of the trade

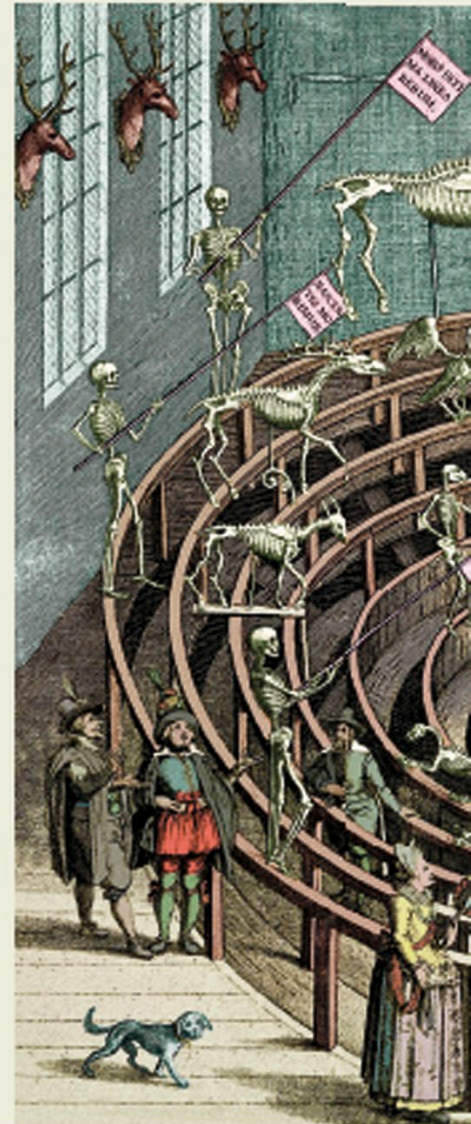
By the Middle Ages, anatomists and surgeons possessed a variety of tools. The German surgeon Hieronymus Brunschwig (c 1450–1513) produced a widely read work, *The Book of Surgery*, which gave advice on how to make cuts and included the first account of treating gunshot wounds.

Leonardo studies the body

Italian artist Leonardo da Vinci (1452–1519) (see pp.58–59) took a keen interest in anatomy and in making accurate drawings of the human body. To gain first-hand knowledge, he attended public dissections. His observations enabled him to produce a series of astonishingly detailed anatomical sketches.



Leonardo learned much anatomy by dissecting animals, probably using the organs of a pig to make this study.



Key events

500 BCE

Greek writer Alcmaeon of Croton stated that the brain is the center of intelligence. He discovered the optic nerves and performed the first dissections of animals.

300 BCE

Known as the "father of anatomy," Herophilus, a Greek from Chalcedon (now in Istanbul, Turkey) understood the difference between veins and arteries, and performed the first public human dissection.

c 50

Roman doctor Rufus of Ephesus wrote *On the Names of the Parts of the Human Body*, the first work to give a detailed list of anatomical body parts.

c 175

Greek physician Galen (see p.29) described the structure of many body parts, including the brain, nervous system, and heart, and showed that arteries carry blood.